such as Social Studies/Pakistan Studies and Islamiyat. This context is important in understanding the narratives that follow in the second part of the chapter, where participant responses highlight how the Pakistani education system perpetuates an uncritical and often restrictive understanding of Islam and the Pakistani identity, teaching students to become loyal subjects rather than active citizens.

Education: A political tool

Education in its very essence of educating individuals or communities is value laden, propagating a philosophy or point of view through the learning experience. Dewey (1910) in his exploration of the role of education in democratic societies emphasized its importance in inculcating democratic values that promote critical reflection for societies to progress. For the critical pedagogues like Paulo Freire (1972), or bell hooks (1994), the role of education was to challenge existing systems of oppression, with education becoming a means of liberation and progress for society. Yet, the same philosophers were also wary of the ability of education systems to produce uncritical automatons to preserve the status quo. The formal education system of Pakistan has proved to be just that, a tool used by the Pakistani state to promote its nationalist agenda of an Islamic Republic, reinforcing the struggle for Pakistan within an Islamic ideological framework, with Pakistan emerging not only as a Muslim homeland but also as a country built on Islamic principles and way of life. The problem with using religion as a means of legitimizing one's citizenship is that religion becomes an exclusive domain of clerics and political actors, removing any possibility of dialogue, where only those deemed acceptable by the religious and political elite become an acceptable part of the national narrative. In religious terms the non-Muslims and the Ahmadiyya communities become second-class citizens in a context where being Pakistani is equated with being Muslim as defined by the state. Given the rise of sectarian and ethnic violence in Pakistan over recent years, the definition of an acceptable Pakistani continues to shrink, and this is reflected in the education system, and the young people that are emerging from these educational institutions.

At its inception, the Pakistani education system, far from celebrating the diversity of the new state, tried to impose a uniform identity by making Urdu, the language of a minority, the national language, and by using Islam to promote a Muslim ideology to unite Pakistan (International Crisis Group 2004; Rahman 2004). In the first education conference the government of Pakistan